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April 30th 2026

Bollywood as a Tool of Political Messaging in Contemporary India

Introduction

Bollywood, the Hindi-language film industry based in Mumbai, occupies a powerful position in shaping cultural, social, and increasingly political narratives in India. With a vast domestic audience and a growing global reach, Bollywood films are not simply forms of entertainment but influential texts that contribute to how people understand identity, nationhood, and collective memory. Cinema in India has historically functioned as a medium through which broader social realities are reflected and interpreted. As Rachel Dwyer argues in *Bollywood's India: Hindi Cinema as a Guide to Contemporary India*, Hindi films often serve as a mirror of national identity, revealing how a society imagines itself at particular historical moments (Dwyer). This reflective quality gives Bollywood a unique ability to both capture and shape public sentiment, making it an important site for examining the intersection of culture and politics.

At the same time, Bollywood is not a neutral or isolated industry operating independently of external influences. Rather, it is deeply embedded within the social, economic, and political contexts in which it is produced. Tejaswini Ganti, in *Producing Bollywood: Inside the Contemporary Hindi Film Industry*, emphasizes that the Hindi film industry evolves alongside broader socioeconomic and sociopolitical changes, with filmmaking practices, narratives, and audience targeting all shaped by these shifting conditions (Ganti). The industry responds to market demands, state policies, and cultural expectations, which means that films often reflect

dominant ideologies or emerging political trends. As a result, what appears on screen is rarely accidental; instead, it is influenced by a complex interplay of institutional pressures, audience preferences, and prevailing political climates .

This relationship between cinema and its surrounding environment allows Bollywood films to move beyond storytelling into the realm of political messaging. Political ideas are not always communicated explicitly through overt statements or direct references to government policies. Instead, they are often embedded within narratives, character portrayals, historical interpretations, and emotional appeals that resonate with audiences. For instance, films that emphasize themes of nationalism, military strength, or cultural pride can reinforce certain political sentiments without necessarily identifying themselves as political texts. Similarly, films that depict historical conflicts or social divisions can shape public perceptions of identity, belonging, and “the nation” in subtle but significant ways. In this sense, Bollywood acts as a form of soft power, influencing how audiences think about political issues through culturally familiar and emotionally engaging formats.

Importantly, this phenomenon is not limited to a single political ideology or time period. Bollywood has historically aligned with different ideological currents, from post-independence nation-building narratives to more recent representations of globalization and nationalism. This suggests that the industry does not operate as a tool of any one political group but rather reflects broader shifts in public sentiment and institutional influence over time. Therefore, instead of viewing Bollywood purely as propaganda or as neutral entertainment, it makes more sense to understand it as a dynamic cultural space where political ideas are continuously produced, negotiated, and consumed.

Bollywood has increasingly reflected and shaped political narratives in contemporary India, with films across different periods aligning with broader ideological trends, state interests, and public sentiment, demonstrating how cinema functions as a subtle but powerful medium of political messaging rather than belonging to any single political group.

Historical Context

In the decades following independence in 1947, Bollywood played an important role in reinforcing themes of nation-building and socialist development. Films of the 1950s and 1960s often focused on rural hardship, class inequality, and collective struggle, reflecting the priorities of the Indian National Congress and the broader Nehruvian vision of a unified and self-reliant nation. Scholars writing in *Economic and Political Weekly* note that Hindi cinema during this period frequently aligned with these ideals, portraying moral narratives that emphasized sacrifice, unity, and social responsibility (*Economic and Political Weekly*). These films helped construct a shared national identity, showing how cinema could both reflect and reinforce political values without explicitly functioning as propaganda.

The 1970s marked a shift in how Bollywood engaged with politics, particularly during the Emergency period (1975–1977), when censorship and political control increased. Direct criticism of the state became difficult, leading filmmakers to adopt more indirect forms of political expression. During this time, the emergence of the “angry young man” figure in Hindi cinema reflected widespread public frustration with corruption and institutional failure. While these films did not openly challenge the government, they captured a growing sense of disillusionment among the public. As Ashish Rajadhyaksha argues, Indian cinema has

historically adapted its narratives to changing political conditions, allowing filmmakers to engage with social tensions even under restrictive environments (Rajadhyaksha).

The economic liberalization of the 1990s introduced another transformation in Bollywood, as globalization and market-oriented reforms reshaped both the film industry and its audiences. Films began to focus more on consumerism, global lifestyles, and the aspirations of the urban middle class. However, political themes did not disappear; instead, they were reconfigured within narratives of cultural identity and belonging. Rajadhyaksha notes that this period reflects a shift in how Indian cinema negotiates national identity in a global context, blending international influences with distinctly Indian themes (Rajadhyaksha). This illustrates that Bollywood continues to engage with political ideas, even when they are less overtly expressed.

In more recent decades, there has been a renewed emphasis on nationalism and historical narratives in Bollywood films, aligning with broader political trends in contemporary India. Discussions in *Economic and Political Weekly* suggest that the relationship between cinema and nationalism is cyclical, with different forms of political expression emerging at different times (*Economic and Political Weekly*). While the tone and content of films have changed, the underlying connection between cinema and politics has remained consistent.

Overall, the historical trajectory of Bollywood demonstrates that political messaging has always been an integral part of Hindi cinema, though its form has evolved across different periods. From nation-building narratives to indirect resistance and from globalization to renewed nationalism, Bollywood has continuously adapted to reflect changing political realities. This long-standing relationship highlights cinema's role not just as entertainment, but as a dynamic medium through which political ideas are shaped and communicated.

Bollywood and Nationalism

In recent years, Bollywood has seen a noticeable rise in films centered around nationalism, military action, and state-led narratives, particularly following the mid-2010s. This shift reflects broader political and social trends in India, where themes of national pride, security, and strength have become more prominent in public discourse. One of the most widely discussed examples is *Uri: The Surgical Strike*, a film based on the Indian Army's response to the 2016 Uri attack. The film not only achieved significant commercial success but also became a cultural moment, widely circulated across social media and political conversations. International media outlets such as BBC and Al Jazeera have noted that films like *Uri* are part of a broader "nationalist wave" in Indian cinema, where narratives of military success and patriotism are emphasized in ways that align with contemporary political sentiment (BBC; Al Jazeera). These interpretations suggest that such films resonate with audiences not only because of their cinematic appeal but also because they reflect and reinforce prevailing ideas about national identity and geopolitical strength.

At the same time, Indian media critics have offered more nuanced perspectives on the political tone of these films. Reviews published in outlets such as *The Hindu* and *The Indian Express* often acknowledge the technical strengths and emotional impact of films like *Uri* while also pointing to their strong patriotic framing. Critics argue that these films rely heavily on emotional narratives of sacrifice, heroism, and unity, which can simplify complex political and military issues into more accessible and compelling storylines. For example, reviews have noted that *Uri* presents a clear and unambiguous narrative of national victory, which can shape how audiences interpret real-world events and state actions (*The Hindu*; *The Indian Express*). This does not

necessarily mean that such films function as direct propaganda; rather, they illustrate how cinema can frame political events in ways that influence public perception.

Beyond Uri, other films such as Kesari (2019) and Tanhaji (2020) similarly emphasize themes of historical pride, military valor, and national unity. These films often draw on real or semi-historical events, presenting them through a lens that highlights courage, sacrifice, and collective identity. The popularity of these narratives indicates a broader cultural interest in stories that reinforce a strong sense of nationhood. At the same time, the timing of their release and the nature of their storytelling suggest that they are part of a wider trend in which Bollywood engages more directly with political themes. As international and domestic analyses indicate, this trend is not occurring in isolation but is closely connected to shifts in political discourse and audience expectations in contemporary India.

Overall, the rise of nationalism and war films in Bollywood demonstrates how cinema can act as a powerful medium for shaping political narratives. While these films are often celebrated for their entertainment value and storytelling, they also contribute to broader conversations about identity, patriotism, and the role of the state. Rather than viewing them as purely neutral or purely propagandistic, it is more useful to understand them as part of an ongoing interaction between cinema and politics, where films both reflect and influence the ways in which audiences engage with national and political issues.

Representation of Internal Threats & Identity

Beyond nationalism and war narratives, Bollywood films have increasingly engaged with themes of internal conflict, religious identity, and historical interpretation, often shaping how audiences understand politically sensitive issues. Films such as *The Kashmir Files*, *Article 370*, and *Tanhaji* illustrate how cinema can present narratives of history and identity in ways that resonate deeply with contemporary political discourse. These films do not simply recount events but interpret them through particular lenses, influencing how viewers perceive complex social and political realities.

One of the most debated examples is *The Kashmir Files*, which portrays the exodus of Kashmiri Pandits in the 1990s. The film generated strong reactions both within India and internationally, highlighting the extent to which cinema can shape political understanding. Coverage from *The Guardian* described the film as highly polarizing, noting that it presents a deeply emotional and one-sided narrative that has sparked intense public debate. Critics argue that while the film brings attention to a historically significant event, its storytelling approach simplifies complex political dynamics and reinforces a specific interpretation of history (*The Guardian*). This demonstrates how films dealing with sensitive issues can influence public perception, particularly when they emphasize emotional intensity over nuance.

Indian digital media platforms have also engaged critically with such representations, offering perspectives that highlight concerns about bias and selective storytelling. Analysis pieces from outlets like *Scroll.in* and *The Wire* argue that films like *The Kashmir Files* and *Article 370* often frame political issues in ways that align with dominant narratives, raising questions about whose voices are included and whose are left out. These critiques suggest that while such films may

claim to present “true” stories, they are shaped by choices about what to emphasize, omit, or dramatize. As a result, cinema becomes a site where competing versions of history and identity are constructed and contested (Scroll.in; The Wire).

Similarly, films like *Tanhaji* draw on historical events to create narratives centered on cultural pride and religious identity. By portraying historical conflicts in ways that emphasize heroism and collective identity, these films can reinforce contemporary ideas about nationalism and belonging. While such portrayals are often celebrated for their storytelling and visual impact, they also contribute to shaping how audiences interpret the past in relation to present-day political concerns. The emotional appeal of these narratives, through dramatic storytelling, music, and character development, further amplifies their influence.

The reception of these films has often been highly polarized, reflecting broader divisions within Indian society and its media landscape. Supporters may view them as necessary correctives that highlight overlooked histories, while critics argue that they risk deepening social and political divides. This polarized response underscores the power of cinema to engage with issues of identity in ways that extend beyond the screen and into public discourse.

Overall, the portrayal of internal threats, religious identity, and historical conflict in Bollywood films demonstrates how cinema can shape public perception of political issues. By presenting emotionally compelling and selectively framed narratives, films influence how audiences understand complex topics related to identity and nationhood. Rather than serving as neutral representations of reality, these films participate in the ongoing construction of political meaning, showing that Bollywood plays a significant role in shaping debates around identity, history, and power.

The Relationship Between the State and Bollywood

The relationship between the Indian state and Bollywood has become increasingly visible in recent years, highlighting how cinema and politics can operate in mutually reinforcing ways. While the film industry has historically maintained a degree of independence, contemporary developments suggest a closer interaction between political leadership and cultural production. Reports from The New York Times have noted that Narendra Modi has actively engaged with members of the film industry, meeting with actors, directors, and producers and publicly acknowledging their influence. These interactions are often framed as efforts to promote Indian culture globally, but they also signal the recognition of Bollywood as a powerful tool for shaping public opinion (The New York Times). When political leaders engage directly with cultural figures, it reinforces the idea that cinema plays an important role in influencing how citizens perceive national identity and political priorities.

In addition to symbolic engagement, there are also material forms of support that further connect the state and the film industry. Coverage from Reuters has highlighted instances in which certain films have received tax exemptions or government backing, particularly those that emphasize themes of nationalism or historical significance. These forms of support can increase a film's accessibility and commercial success, thereby amplifying its reach and impact. While such policies are often justified as promoting cultural heritage or supporting the film industry, they also raise questions about whether certain types of narratives are being privileged over others (Reuters). This does not necessarily indicate direct control over cinematic content, but it does suggest that there are structural incentives that can shape which stories are told and how they are distributed.

At the same time, it is important to recognize that the relationship between the state and Bollywood is not purely one-directional. Filmmakers and actors also benefit from aligning with political narratives that resonate with audiences, as such alignment can increase visibility, marketability, and public relevance. This mutual relationship illustrates how cinema and politics can reinforce each other without requiring explicit coordination. Rather than viewing Bollywood as simply an instrument of the state, it is more accurate to understand this relationship as a dynamic exchange in which both parties influence and benefit from one another. Ultimately, the growing interaction between the state and the film industry further supports the idea that Bollywood operates within a broader political context, where cultural production and political messaging are closely intertwined.

Counter-Argument: Diversity and Interpretation in Bollywood

Despite the increasing visibility of political themes in Bollywood, it is important to avoid reducing the industry to a single ideological perspective. Not all films reinforce dominant political narratives, and many actively critique social and political structures. For example, Article 15 addresses issues of caste discrimination and systemic inequality, presenting a narrative that challenges existing power structures rather than supporting them. Films like this demonstrate that Bollywood remains a diverse space where different viewpoints can coexist, even within a politically charged environment. Such examples complicate the argument that the industry uniformly promotes a particular ideology, showing instead that it includes voices of critique and resistance.

In addition to the diversity of film content, audience interpretation also plays a crucial role in shaping the political impact of cinema. Academic discussions in journals such as the *Journal of South Asian Film Studies* emphasize that films do not carry fixed meanings; rather, their interpretation depends on the perspectives, experiences, and beliefs of viewers. This means that the same film can be understood in multiple ways, depending on the audience engaging with it. A film that one viewer sees as a celebration of national identity may be interpreted by another as overly simplistic or politically motivated. This variability highlights the limitations of viewing cinema as a straightforward tool of political messaging.

Furthermore, the global nature of Bollywood complicates its political role. Films are consumed not only within India but also by diasporic and international audiences, each bringing their own contexts to interpretation. As a result, the political meanings of films are constantly negotiated rather than fixed. While some films may align with dominant political narratives or receive state support, others challenge these narratives or offer alternative perspectives. This diversity suggests that Bollywood cannot be fully understood as either neutral entertainment or political propaganda.

Overall, while Bollywood clearly engages with political themes and can shape public perception, it remains a complex and multifaceted industry. The presence of critical films and diverse audience interpretations demonstrates that cinema operates as a space of negotiation rather than uniform messaging. Recognizing this complexity strengthens the broader argument of this paper: Bollywood reflects and shapes political narratives, but it does so in varied and evolving ways rather than serving any single ideology.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Bollywood cannot be understood as either purely entertainment or straightforward political propaganda. Instead, it operates as a dynamic cultural space where political ideas are continuously shaped, reflected, and contested. Across different historical periods, the industry has adapted to changing political contexts, from post-independence nation-building to contemporary nationalist narratives. Films centered on war, history, and identity demonstrate how cinema can influence public perception by framing complex issues through emotionally compelling storytelling. At the same time, the presence of critical films and diverse audience interpretations highlights that Bollywood does not promote a single, unified ideology. Rather, it reflects a broader negotiation between state influence, market forces, and public sentiment. This complexity reinforces the central argument of this paper: Bollywood functions as a subtle but powerful medium of political messaging, shaping how audiences understand identity, history, and the nation, while remaining an evolving and contested space of cultural production.

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